

LEVELHULL · CALCULATION NOTE

LevelHull sizing calculations

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DOCUMENT CONTROL

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Author	Amish Chadha	License	CERN-OHL-S-2.0
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REVISION HISTORY

Version	Date	Author	Change
0.1	2026-10-03	Amish Chadha	First issue at TRL 3, on the constructable design of LVH-DDR-002

LevelHull sizing calculations

On paper, eight foam modules of 0.38 m³ in all, fitted high under the gunwales of the 8 m reference canoe, keep the swamped canoe afloat with its motor, gear, catch and four crew holding on, with 80 mm of freeboard at the lowest point of the gunwale, level within half a degree and with 2.2 times the needed lift in reserve at 50 mm freeboard. The same foam laid low on the floor would leave the swamped canoe almost neutral in roll, and it would roll over with the crew on one side: that comparison is why the modules sit under the gunwale. The weak points are the low-side freeboard with all four crew on one side (31 mm), the damaged case (9 mm with the largest module lost) and the cost, which is USD 350 over the value-engineering target for two canoes.

Every figure comes from `docs/04-calcs/sizing.py`, which imports the parametric model (`cad/src/model.py`), so the sizes here are those of the STEP files, the drawings and the build plan. Tags in square brackets match the script output and `docs/04-calcs/results.csv`. The script is also the open sizing calculator for other hulls (section 8). These are screening estimates for a paper proof of concept; they do not replace the swamp test, which is TRL 4 work.

Safety: LevelHull is flotation for a boat, not lifesaving equipment, and is never a substitute for life jackets. These numbers are for a design review. No fitted canoe is used for fishing before its fixings are pull-tested and it has passed a swamp test in sheltered, shallow water with a safety boat and every person in a life jacket.

■ 1. Method and assumptions

The swamped canoe is treated as a set of solid bodies floating in the lake. The water inside the hull is part of the lake and carries nothing. Each body gives lift equal to the water its submerged part displaces and weighs its own mass; the canoe floats where total lift equals total weight. Small heel and trim follow from the second moments of the waterplane (the strips where the modules and planks cut the water surface) and the heights of the lift and the weights: $\text{roll stiffness} = \text{water density} \times \text{waterplane moment} + \text{lift} \times \text{height of the centre of lift} - \text{weight} \times \text{height of the centre of weight}$.

Table 1. Assumptions.

#	Assumption	Value	Basis
A1	Water density	1,000 kg/m ³ (lakes); 1,025 kg/m ³ checked	Design case is fresh water
A2	Wet hull timber density	1,000 kg/m ³ : no net lift from the hull	Conservative (LVH-DDR-001, D3); 750 kg/m ³ reported as a margin
A3	Crew holding on	20 % of 75 kg each (15 kg), at the gunwale	Head and shoulders out of the water; four crew
A4	Outboard motor	36 kg at full weight, 0.25 m aft of the transom	15 hp two-stroke; mostly above water when swamped
A5	Gear and catch	12 kg steel anchor, 40 kg nylon nets, 150 kg fish, full fuel tank	Net in water 10.5, 4.9, 7.1 and 0 kg (a full tank floats)
A6	Foam	Closed-cell polyethylene, 30 kg/m ³ , under 1 % water uptake by volume	Supplier data to confirm
A7	Kit hardware in water	Covers 8.9 kg PVC, steel 2.8 kg, straps 3.3 kg; battens neutral	Densities 1,300, 7,850 and 1,380 kg/m ³
A8	Bailing	100 L per minute per person with a 10 L bucket, two bailers, calm water	Estimate
A9	Fixing strengths	Webbing 10 kN, D-ring pair 4 kN, M8 coach screw 1.5 kN sideways in hardwood	To confirm with real parts

■ 2. Geometry of the kit

Table 2. Kit geometry (reference canoe).

Tag	Quantity	Value
[G1]	Side flare of the canoe	31.6 deg
[G2], [G3]	Modules	8; 4.78 m a side (880, 1,400, 1,400 and 1,100 mm)
[G4]	Module section	200 mm wide (level) x 200 mm high, a parallelogram matching the flare
[G5], [G6]	Module volume; foam inside the covers	0.382 m ³ ; 0.365 m ³
[G7]	Module bottom and top above the outside of the bottom	420 and 620 mm (top 30 mm below the gunwale)
[G8], [G9]	Hull timber; dry hull mass at 750 kg/m ³	0.586 m ³ ; 439 kg
[K1]	Kit mass	67.4 kg (battens and chocks 39.4 kg, foam 10.9 kg, covers 8.9 kg)

■ 3. Swamped, design load

Table 3. Swamped canoe at the design load, fresh water.

Tag	Result	Value
[L1]	Design net load	118 kg
[F4]	Timber above the water, counted as load	104 kg
[F1]	Freeboard amidships, level	105 mm
[F3]	Trim	0.45 deg stern down
[F2]	Lowest freeboard on the gunwale (transom)	80 mm
[F5], [F6]	Metacentric height; roll stiffness	3.1 m; 742 kg m per radian
[F7], [F8]	Net load carried at 50 mm freeboard; reserve	257 kg; 2.17 times the design load
[F9]	No crew holding on	119 mm lowest freeboard, 0 deg heel, 0.17 deg trim

■ 4. Off-design cases

Table 4. Off-design cases.

Tag	Case	Result
[F10], [F11]	All four crew holding the port grab line	4.0 deg heel; low-side freeboard 31 mm
[F12]	Salt water	87 mm lowest freeboard
[F13]	Foam lift down 5 % (the R6 limit)	74 mm lowest freeboard
[F14], [F15]	Largest module (port 2) lost, and 5 % uptake	9 mm lowest freeboard; 1.5 deg heel
[F16]	Typical 750 kg/m ³ timber (lift not counted in the design)	163 mm freeboard amidships

■ 5. Why the modules are high: low placement compared

The TRL 1 concept placed the modules low along the sides. With the same 0.38 m³ of foam on the floor (85 to 285 mm up), the foam is fully under water and cuts no waterline, so only the thin planks give any waterplane, while the motor and the crew's hands act high on the canoe.

Table 5. Same foam, high or low.

Tag	Quantity	High under the gunwale	Low on the floor
[F6], [F17]	Roll stiffness, kg m per radian	742	17
[F5], [F18]	Metacentric height	3.1 m	0.04 m
[F10], [F19]	Four crew on one side	4.0 deg heel	Rolls over (small-angle heel beyond 90 deg)

This is the result behind decision D1 in LVH-DDR-001. It matches the practice in the USCG level flotation method, where flotation that keeps a swamped boat upright sits high in the hull.

■ 6. Space, bailing and the dry canoe

Table 6. Space and bailing.

Tag	Quantity	Value
[V1], [V2]	Inside volume below the gunwale; share taken by the modules	5.01 m ³ ; 7.6 %
[B1]	Water inside the swamped canoe	3.57 m ³
[B2]	Water that can stay aboard at 200 mm freeboard, all crew and gear aboard	2.31 m ³
[B3], [B4]	Water to bail; time for two crew	1.26 m ³ ; about 6.3 minutes (estimate)
	Time to bail the canoe dry at the same rate	about 18 minutes (estimate)
[B5]	Dry canoe: added draft from the 67 kg kit	about 11 mm

The clear width between the module tops is 963 mm, and the modules take the upper side of the canoe, where little catch is stowed.

■ 7. Fixings

The worst case for a fixing is a module pushed fully under water (a breaking wave or a canoe on its side), in salt water.

Table 7. Fixing loads.

Tag	Quantity	Value	Factor (R7 needs 2)
[S1]	Largest module (1,400 mm), full lift	0.547 kN	
[S2], [S3]	Per strap (two straps); each leg half of that	0.273 kN	Webbing 73
[S4]	D-ring pair, 4 kN to confirm	0.273 kN	14.6
[S5], [S6]	Per coach screw, sideways (largest share, two screws)	0.273 kN	5.5
[S7], [S8]	All modules fully under water; per frame	3.73 kN; 0.187 kN	

The frames take 0.187 kN each into their existing fastenings to the planks. The condition of those fastenings is checked on every hull before fitting (build plan, first checks).

■ 8. Fitting time, cost and the sizing sheet

- [T1] Fitting on the canoe takes about 6.3 hours for a builder and a helper, with the foam cores and covers made beforehand (estimate): marking 40 minutes, battens 120, screws 60, chocks 40, straps and modules 50, eye bolts and grab lines 50, marks and bailers 20.

- [C1], [C2] Parts cost USD 677 for one kit and USD 1,350 for two canoes (one gauge). Value-engineering target: USD 1,000. Estimated cost of the constructable design: USD 1,350 (USD 350 over the target). [C3] Foam is 49 % of a kit.

The sizing sheet uses a simple prismatic estimate: modules 200 x 200 mm, top 30 mm below the gunwale, and enough run per side to carry 1.5 times the design net load plus the timber above the water at 50 mm freeboard.

Table 8. Sizing sheet for other hulls (estimates; measure each hull).

Hull	Module run needed per side	Run free of thwarts
6.5 m paddle canoe, no motor, 3 crew	2.7 m	3.8 m
8.0 m canoe, 15 hp, 4 crew (reference)	4.2 m	4.8 m fitted
10 m canoe, 25 hp, 6 crew	5.6 m	6.4 m

■ 9. Results against the requirements

Table 9. Results against LVH-REQ-001.

ID	Target	Result	Status
R1	Afloat with design load	2.2 times the design load carried at 50 mm freeboard	Met on paper
R2	At least 50 mm freeboard	80 mm lowest	Met on paper
R3	Heel and trim within 10 deg	0 deg heel, 0.45 deg trim	Met on paper
R4	Bail in 15 min or less	About 6 minutes to 200 mm freeboard	Met on paper (estimate)
R5	10 % or less of inside volume	7.6 %	Met
R6	Under 5 % uptake	Under 1 % on supplier data	To confirm by test
R7	Fixings 2 times their share	Lowest factor 5.5 (coach screw)	Met on paper
R8	Fitted in a day	About 6.3 hours	Met on paper (estimate)
R9	12 months without loss	Not shown on paper	Needs field trial (TRL 4 and later)
R10	Value-engineering target USD 1,000 for two canoes	USD 1,350	Over the value-engineering target by USD 350
R11	Reserve 1.5	2.17	Met on paper
R12	Afloat with largest module lost	9 mm freeboard	Met on paper, small margin
R13	Heel within 10 deg, crew on one side	4.0 deg; low side 31 mm	Met on paper